Building the Good Stuff

Hope, strengths, and steady connection. Prepared for the Rising Above Community.

Much of the work we talk about begins with what has been hard. This packet turns toward what can grow. Research on positive childhood experiences (PCEs) suggests that everyday supports, like feeling safe with an adult, having someone who listens, and belonging somewhere, are linked to better adult well-being, even for people who faced adversity. You can build these now, whatever your past looks like.

A note on the research. These studies rely on adults remembering their childhoods, and they show association, not cause. Use this packet to notice strengths and take small steps. It is not a score for your past, and it is not a test of your parenting.

If things feel heavy right now, you do not have to carry this alone. If you feel unsafe, or you are worried about someone's safety, call 911. If you are having thoughts of harming yourself, call or text 988 (in the US). For support with domestic violence, the National Domestic Violence Hotline is 1-800-799-7233.

How to use this packet

- Go in any order. Start with whichever section feels most useful today.
- Work on paper, and come back to it when a week feels hard.
- Keep the hope plan where you will see it. Pair it with the reset card.
- Pair this with *My Vision Board*, a private tool for parents to keep their focus on their children while making separation and co-parenting decisions, available at GradientResolutions.com.

Part 1: The Seven Positive Experiences

Read each experience. Check the box if it is already part of your life or your child's life. Then choose one small step you could take for any that are not yet there. For a child or teen, this might look like a parent who talks about feelings out loud and an adult outside the family who notices them.

#	Positive experience	Already here	One small step I can take
1	Able to talk with family about feelings	☐	
2	Family stood by them during difficult times	☐	
3	Felt safe and protected by an adult at home	☐	
4	At least two non-parent adults took a genuine interest	☐	
5	Felt supported by friends	☐	
6	Felt a sense of belonging somewhere (school, team, group, or community)	☐	
7	Enjoyed taking part in community traditions	☐	

Small steps count. Choosing one and trying it for a week is a real start.

Part 2: A Hope Plan

> A goal without a plan is just a wish. Hope gets real when you can name the next step.

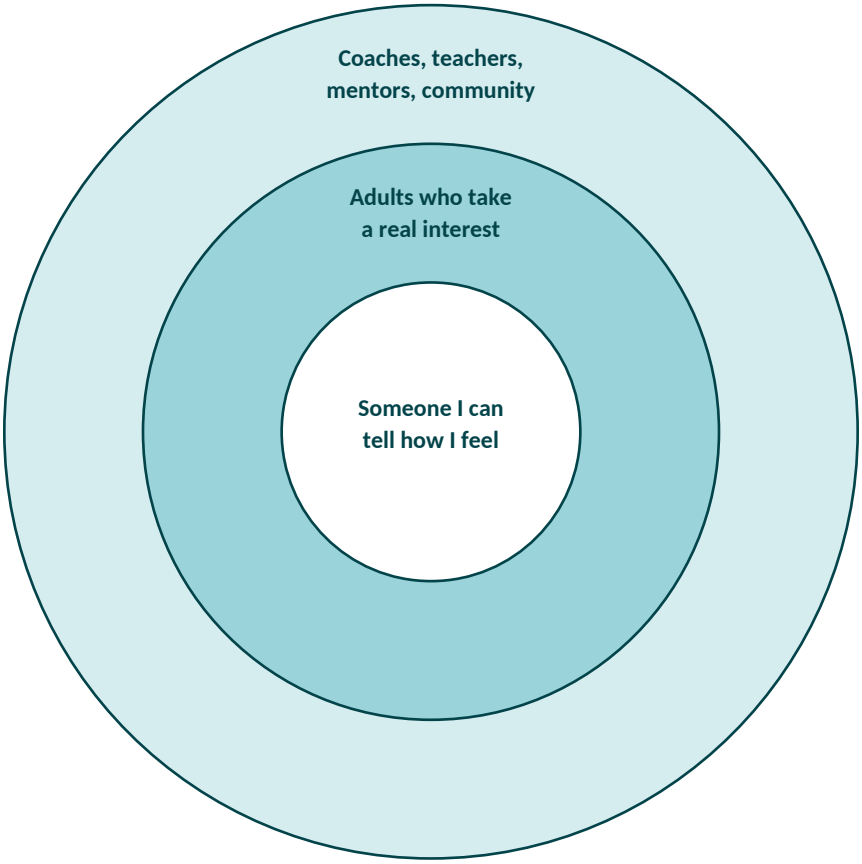
Fill in what you can today. You can come back to any line at any time.

The hope I am building toward (in my own words)	
The next step I can take this week	
Who is in my corner (up to three people)	
One thing I will do when it gets hard	
Check-in date (when I will look at this again)	

Hope is built step by step. You can name it, practice it, and adjust it.

Part 3: My Trusted Adults

Children and teens do better with more than one caring adult. Adults do too. Think about who is in each ring, and write names in the space provided. The inner ring holds the people you can talk to honestly about how you feel. The middle ring holds people who take a real interest in you or your child. The outer ring holds coaches, teachers, mentors, neighbors, and community groups.



Inner ring: safe harbor Middle ring: steady allies Outer ring: wider support

To sketch out your child's temperament, try the *Temperament Field Notes*, a free fillable sheet at GradientResolutions.com.

Do you feel like you have a clear image of who your child is? If not, which of these trusted adults might I reach out to talk to?

Part 4: The Reset Card

Cut out this card and keep it where you can see it, such as on the fridge, in your bag, or on your phone's lock screen photo.

THE 60-SECOND RESET

1. Feel your feet on the floor.
A simple, physical anchor to the present moment.

2. Take one or two slow, deliberate breaths.
Not a fix. Just enough to interrupt the cycle.

3. Look around and name three colors you see.
It moves you from emotion toward thinking.

4. Unclench your jaw and drop your shoulders.
A small physical reset before you walk in.

This is a pause, not a fix. One reset will not undo months of tension, but it can interrupt today's moment.

Modeling a reset speaks louder than explaining one. When you use it in front of the people you care about, you show them that steadiness can be learned.

Keep Building, One Step at a Time

Hope is something you can practice, and you do not have to build it alone. If you would like more support, Laura teaches parent-education classes online through Poway Adult School:

- **Understanding What Your Teen Is Really Saying** explores how to adapt your parenting as your teen grows.
- **Personal Stress and Anxiety** focuses on building your own self-care, so you can steady yourself and help your children through regulation and co-regulation.

Find current dates and details at GradientResolutions.com.

Also free at GradientResolutions.com: *Temperament Field Notes*, a fillable sheet for understanding your child's temperament, and *My Vision Board*.

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It is not about what is fair. It is about what is possible, for you and your kids.